Electoral gains in 1952 by a coalition of communist and socialist parties in a southern Indian state made it clear that India was not immune to communism. American and Indian policymakers were apprehensive that communists could take advantage of disillusionment with the government's ability to deliver.[259] The danger of the loss of India seemed more real. This helped Delhi in one way— Dennis Merrill argues that the communist gains were "the decisive factor" in Acheson increasing the aid request for India for FY1953.[260]

A reappraisal of NSC-68 in summer/fall 1952 further highlighted the importance of the free world developing "greater stability in peripheral or other unstable areas."[261] Traveling with Eisenhower on the campaign trail, a journalist called for less of the blame game and more attention to what a new administration could do: "China is gone, yes.… But there are perhaps four years in which we can help save India."[262] Bowles also continued to link Indian economic development to US security interests.[263] An intelligence estimate that October assisted his cause: "[C]oming on the heels of the Communist victory in China, [the loss of South Asia] would create the impression throughout non-Communist Asia, Africa, and Europe that the advance of Communism was inevitable."[264]

In India, Nehru tried to do his part by pointedly acknowledging American aid publicly. He noted that the US had sent assistance with the "very best of motives and without strings of any kind." While Nehru believed that the communists in India were weaker than six months before, he told Bowles of his government's concern that directly and indirectly Beijing had "done a disturbingly effective job of selling China as a new land of milk and honey"—all achieved through communism, rather than democracy.[265]

In the US, by the time Eisenhower took office in 1953, there was no longer a debate on *whether* defense (of the US and the "free world") and development (of India and other developing countries) were connected. Even though some continued to argue against aid for India, the key point of discussion became *how much* aid India should receive. The lame-duck Truman administration had left office suggesting that the new administration allocate over four times the amount of aid India had received the previous year. Acheson had argued that it would help keep India on the side of the "democratic free world" and serve as an example.[266] The